

FRED TALKS

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What I Learned About Billionaires at Jeff Bezos's Private Retreat

NOAH HAWLEY · 02 MAY 2026 · [SOURCE](#)

For the richest men on Earth, everything is free and nothing matters.



(Illustration by Tim Enthoven)

At the end of Paul Thomas Anderson's 2007 movie, *There Will Be Blood*, Daniel Day-Lewis's oil-baron character, old now and richer than Croesus, beats Paul Dano's preacher to death with a bowling pin. Dano's Eli Sunday, a nemesis of Day-Lewis's Daniel Plainview during his seminal, wealth-building years, has come to sell Plainview the oil-rich land that he once coveted. But Plainview doesn't need the land anymore, because—as he explains in one of the most famous monologues in modern cinema—he has sucked out all the oil hidden beneath it from an adjoining property, like a milkshake.

Desperate for money, Eli begs for a loan. Instead, Plainview chases him around a bowling alley and murders him with great enthusiasm. Once it's over, a butler comes to see what all the noise was about. "I'm finished," Plainview yells.

No matter how many times I watch that movie, and I watch it a lot, I have never once taken those words to mean *I'm done for. There will now be consequences for my actions*. Quite the opposite: They mean that Plainview has completed his journey, through the acquisition of wealth and power, to a realm outside the moral universe. He's finished, in other words, pretending that the rules of human society apply to him.

In 2018, I was a guest at Jeff Bezos's Campfire retreat in Santa Barbara, California. It's an annual event in which the Amazon founder invites 80-plus guests—celebrities, artists, intellectuals, and anyone else he thinks is interesting—to spend three nights at a private resort. I

had recently been approached by Amazon about moving my film-and-television business over from Disney, and although I had declined (or maybe *because* I had declined), Bezos's team invited me to Campfire, perhaps keen to impress me with the power of his reach.

From the March 2024 issue: The rise of techno-authoritarianism

On a warm October Thursday, a fleet of private jets was dispatched to airports in Van Nuys and New York to shepherd guests to Santa Barbara in style. At that point I had only a vague sense of who else was coming—famous people, rich people, influential people, and me. A guest list, I was told, would be given to us once we arrived. Families were invited; an on-site nanny would be provided *for each child*.

So my wife and I got our two children from Austin to Los Angeles and took a 45-minute jet ride north, with a television mogul and a comedian on board. Bezos had bought out the entire Biltmore resort for the weekend, as well as the beach club across the street. He had brought in a security firm from Las Vegas to ensure our safety and privacy. Even the weather felt expensive, and when we were shown to our rooms, the designer gift bags we found were filled with luxury goods.

Alexandra Petri: The 10 things the Bezoses are almost certainly grateful for each morning

Each morning, we gathered in a lecture hall to hear presentations. If you've ever seen a TED Talk, you understand the format. The year I went, a sitting Supreme Court justice was interviewed, and a neurologist talked about technological advances in prosthetics. In the afternoons and evenings, we were encouraged to exchange ideas over drinks and four-course meals, with no set purpose—to network, in other words, with some of the most rarefied talent on Earth. The most common question I heard was “Why am I here?”

“Why am I here?” asked the 1980s hair-metal singer. “Why am I here?” asked the Pulitzer Prize-winning novelist, the famous anthropologist, the presidential historian. Only the movie stars and the billionaires didn't ask: They had done this kind of thing before. It turns out there is a circuit of idea festivals. Many tech billionaires host one, and if you find yourself on the right list, you can spend much of the year traveling the world, eating Wagyu, and discussing how to make the world a better place with the most famous talk-show host in history.

That's how the weekend started. Here's how it ended: My wife broke her wrist slipping on wet grass, and both children and I came down with hand, foot, and mouth disease. This is not a joke. One of us went home with her arm in a sling; the other three developed itchy, painful red blisters all over our faces and extremities. If you're looking for a sign from God as to whether hanging

out with the richest man on Earth is right for you, pay attention when he sends you not one plague, but two. Suffice it to say we have never been back to Campfire, nor have we ever been invited.

At drinks on the second night, the head of a major talent agency asked me what I thought of the weekend. I said, “I’ve spent my whole career trying to figure out how the world works. I didn’t realize I could just come here and ask the people who ran it.” On some level I was kidding. The lead singer of an alt-country band didn’t run the world, nor did a noted author who would later be accused of impropriety. But finding myself at that resort by exclusive invitation, I now knew exactly what people meant when they talked about the elite.

Sitting in the lecture hall, pencils out, listening to a famous chef explain his humanitarian work, it was easy to feel like the solution to the world’s problems lay within our grasp. And yet, looking around at faces I had only ever seen in a magazine or on-screen, I had an unsettling revelation: This is the hubris of accomplishment. To be declared a genius at one thing is to begin to believe you are a genius at everything.

Here we were, 80 individuals with a combined net worth that was greater than a small city’s yet infinitesimal compared with the wealth and dominion of our host. How did he view this exercise—as a first step toward changing the world, or as a performative display of his reach and influence?

Bezos was everywhere that weekend—in a tight T-shirt, laughing too loudly, arms thrown around his teenage sons. He had recently become the world’s second centibillionaire, his net worth hovering somewhere around \$112 billion, about half of what it is today. That number, previously unimaginable, had made him unique on a planet of 8 billion people, and you could feel it in the room. Even the richest and most famous among us were drawn to the energy of this impossible wealth.

Martin Baron: Where Jeff Bezos went wrong with *The Washington Post*

Though we didn’t know it at the time, Bezos’s first marriage would be over a few weeks later. My defining impression of his wife that weekend was sadness, even though Bezos made a big show of performing the role of family man. In hindsight, it is that performance that sticks with me. The Jeff Bezos of 2018 acted as if he still believed that people’s impression of him mattered, that his financial and social value could be affected by negative publicity. He still believed that his actions had consequences. He had not yet freed himself—the way Daniel Plainview freed himself—from the rules of men.

Eight years later, Bezos and two of the world's other richest men—Mark Zuckerberg and Elon Musk—have clearly left the world of consequences behind. They float in a sensory-deprivation tank the size of the planet, in which their actions are only ever judged by themselves.

The closer I've gotten to the world of wealth, the more I understand that being truly rich doesn't mean amassing enough money to afford superyachts, private jets, or a million acres of land. It means that everything becomes effectively free. Any asset can be acquired but nothing can ever be lost, because for soon-to-be trillionaires, no level of loss could significantly change their global standing or personal power. For them, the word *failure* has ceased to mean anything.

Adam Serwer: How America chose not to hold the powerful to account

This sense of invulnerability has deep psychological ramifications. If everything is free and nothing matters, then the world and other people exist only to be acted upon, if they are acknowledged at all. This is different from classic narcissism, in which a grandiose but fragile self-image can mask deep insecurity. What I'm talking about is a self-definition in which the individual grows to the size of the universe, and the universe vanishes. Asked recently if there is any check on his power, President Trump—himself a billionaire, and by far the richest president in American history—said, “Yeah, there is one thing. My own morality. My own mind. It's the only thing that can stop me.” Not domestic or international law, not the will of the voters, not God or the centuries-old morality of civic and religious life.

Decades of research in developmental psychology have shown that moral reasoning develops through consequences—not punishment, necessarily, but experiencing the effects of your actions on others, receiving honest feedback, having to accommodate reality as it actually is rather than as you wish it to be. It's not that the wealthy become evil; it's that their environment stops teaching them the things that nonwealthy people are forced to learn simply by living in a world that pushes back. When you can buy your way out of any mistake, when you can fire anyone who disagrees with you, when your social circle consists entirely of people who need something from you, the basic mechanism by which humans learn that other people are real goes dark.

Thomas Chatterton Williams: The very powerful men who think introspection is dumb

When Peter Thiel said, “I no longer believe that freedom and democracy are compatible,” he wasn't talking about your freedom. He was talking about his own. You don't exist. When Musk took a chainsaw to the federal government as part of the inside joke he called DOGE, he did so with the air of a man who believed that nothing matters—poverty, chaos, human suffering. He was having fun. It didn't even matter that the entire destructive exercise ultimately yielded no practical financial gains. For him, the outcome was a foregone conclusion: He could only win, because losing had lost its meaning.

Since the 2024 election, there has been a philosophical shift on the right, and especially among tech billionaires, to vilify the idea of empathy. Musk has called empathy “the fundamental weakness of Western civilization.” He sees it as a weapon wielded by liberal society to bludgeon otherwise rational people into operating against their own interests. Empathy is something done to you by others—a vulnerability they exploit, a back door through which they gain access to your resources and will. This rejection of empathy as a human value gives cover to people who don’t want to feel anything at all. If empathy is the problem, then lack of it isn’t a deficiency—it’s an advantage.

Elizabeth Bruenig: The conservative attack on empathy

I finally met Bezos on the last day of Campfire, at lunch, after my wife had broken her wrist. I went over to thank him for having us, and he asked how our Campfire experience had been. I told him that it was great, but that unfortunately my wife had broken her wrist that morning when she slipped on the wet grass while kicking a ball with our 6-year-old son.

The night before, we’d all stood by the pool at the beach club watching a cadre of synchronized swimmers execute a flawless water routine. I had spoken with a famous novelist, who said, “I just don’t understand why I’m here.” A famous rock star was about to start an acoustic set. The famous chef had made paella. Somewhere deep under my skin, a brutal pox was beginning to form.

The next morning, my wife fell, and I found myself in a black SUV with a team of private-security contractors, who whisked us to the back entrance of a Santa Barbara emergency room, where she was seen and treated right away. We made it back in time to watch the Supreme Court justice Zoom in from Washington, D.C.

How was your Campfire? Bezos asked me an hour later, and because I am an honest person, and because I have been a host myself, I decided he would want to know that there had been a problem, but that his team had reacted quickly and been extremely helpful. To be clear, I was in no way blaming him, nor was I shaking down the richest man on Earth. Instead, I was simply offering Bezos, also a husband and father, a brief human connection.

But when I told him what had happened, Bezos looked horrified. He did not say “I’m so sorry.” He did not say “Do you need anything?” Instead, he made a face, and in an instant, an aide came and whisked him away. When presented with the opportunity for empathy, even performative empathy, he chose escape.

A few hours later, on the private plane home, a famous movie producer offered my wife a blanket. My children's faces were covered in spots. Under my fingernails, red welts were beginning to rise.

The world has always been run by rich men. The robber barons of the Gilded Age were known for their ruthlessness in the accumulation of wealth—hiring Pinkertons to shoot striking unionists. But they directly engaged with the world around them, using their wealth and power to muscle it into its most profitable form. And although today's billionaires are clearly manipulating society to maximize their own profit, something else is also happening—a disassociation from the reality of cause and effect, from meaning and history. These men no longer feel the need to change the world in order to succeed, because their success is guaranteed, no matter what happens to the rest of us.

"I'm finished," yells Daniel Plainview, perched happily on the polished floor of his own celestial kingdom. Though he has just committed a crime, he has never felt so free.

This article appears in the May 2026 print edition with the headline "Everything Is Free and Nothing Matters."

Mastering Codex Remote for engineering

DEVELOPERS.OPENAI.COM · 25 JUN 2026 · [SOURCE](#)

Codex Remote is easy to underestimate.

At first glance, it looks like a way to check on a coding task from your phone. That is useful, but it misses the bigger idea. The real power of Codex Remote is that it lets you start, direct, review, and organize work running on your development machines without pretending that an iPhone should be a tiny terminal.

Over the last two months, we have added a surprising amount of depth to that loop: remote host connections, worktrees, goals, side chats, inline code review, queued and steering prompts, attachments, skills and plugins, archived threads, security controls, and a long tail of small details that make the app useful for serious work.

This is the field guide I wish every new power user had.



The right mental model: Your phone is the control plane

The code still runs where it belongs: on your Mac, Windows machine, devbox, or other connected host. Codex Remote gives you a native interface for controlling that work.

That distinction matters. The goal is not to reproduce every terminal affordance on a small screen. The goal is to make the decisions that unblock an agent easy from anywhere:

- What repository and workspace should it use?
- Should this run in the current branch or a fresh worktree?
- Should my next message wait, or should it redirect the active turn?
- Is this command safe to approve?
- What changed, and do I agree with it?
- Should this become a durable goal, a separate thread, or a quick side question?

Once you use the app this way, it stops feeling like remote desktop software and starts feeling like an engineering control plane.

1. Start the task with the right boundaries

Good agent work starts with a correctly scoped environment. Codex Remote lets you choose the connected host and workspace before the first prompt. For a new thread, you can also choose a branch, create a separate worktree, and run the environment setup associated with it.

That makes a few useful patterns possible:

- Use the current checkout for a quick investigation.

- Create a new worktree for a change that should stay isolated.
- Start from the intended base branch instead of fixing Git state later.
- Let the environment setup run before asking Codex to build or test.

This is one of the most important power-user habits: Spend 10 seconds choosing the right execution context and save 10 minutes of cleanup later.

The composer can also carry more context than plain text. You can attach files, photos, or a fresh camera capture. Skills and plugins appear inline, which makes it much easier to confirm that your prompt is invoking the capability you intended.

My rule is simple: If a screenshot, file, or named skill can remove ambiguity, attach or mention it before the first turn.

2. Learn the difference between Queue and Steer

This is probably the least obvious high-leverage setting in Codex Remote.

When Codex is already working, a follow-up can do one of two things:

- **Queue** waits until the current response finishes, then sends your prompt as the next turn.
- **Steer** injects guidance into the work already in progress.

Queue is the safe default. Use it for a second task, an extra test request, or anything that should happen after the current work.

Steer is for correcting direction while the cost of continuing down the wrong path is still growing:

- | Keep the fix inside the mobile package. Do not refactor the shared renderer.
- | The reproduction only happens after reconnect. Test the resumed path, not the live path.
- | Stop investigating the UI. Check whether the server removed the item during resume.

That turns the phone into something more useful than a status screen. You can intervene at the exact moment a run needs judgment.

You can choose the default follow-up behavior in Codex settings. I keep Queue as the default and use Steer deliberately; accidental mid-turn redirection is usually more expensive than waiting.

3. Use side chats as a branch of thought

Long-running coding threads accumulate valuable context. Interrupting one with every side question makes the main transcript noisy and can pull the agent away from the objective.

That is what side chats solve.

Use `/side` to open a lightweight conversation connected to the current thread. Use `/side <prompt>` to open it with a question already prepared. Even better, select text in the transcript and choose **Ask in side chat**. The selected passage becomes the starting context for the new conversation.

I use side chats for questions such as:

- Why did Codex choose this architecture?
- What does this error actually mean?
- Is this behavior consistent with the desktop app?
- Give me a release-note version of this implementation detail.
- What should I verify before I approve this command?

The distinction is useful: The main thread owns the work; the side chat helps me understand the work.

4. Use Plan for the path and Goal for the outcome

Plan mode and goals solve different problems.

Plan mode asks Codex to propose the implementation path before changing code. It is useful when the task is underspecified, risky, or likely to touch several systems.

A goal is durable. It tells Codex what outcome to keep pursuing across turns. On mobile, `/goal` can create and manage that objective, while progress remains visible as the work continues.

A practical pattern is:

1. Start with Plan mode for a risky change.
2. Inspect the proposed boundaries.
3. Turn the accepted outcome into a goal when the work will require multiple iterations.
4. Let Codex continue through implementation, tests, review feedback, and cleanup without restating the objective every time.

Plans answer “How should we approach this?” Goals answer “What must be true before we are done?”

5. Review code without leaving the conversation

The review loop is where Codex Remote becomes genuinely useful for engineering rather than merely convenient.

Completed turns can show a summary of changed files. From there, you can open the diff, inspect individual files, expand or collapse sections, wrap long lines, and open a source file with syntax highlighting. You can attach inline comments to the relevant lines and send that review context back to Codex.

There are several levels to the workflow:

- Open the changed-file summary for a quick sanity check.
- Tap through to the full source when a diff lacks surrounding context.
- Add inline comments for precise corrections.
- Use the review command to review local changes or compare against a branch.
- Link a file back into the chat when you want Codex to reason about that file specifically.

This makes a tight mobile review loop possible:

1. Codex completes the implementation.
2. I inspect the diff from my phone.

3. I leave two inline comments.
4. Codex addresses them in the same thread.
5. I review the smaller follow-up diff.

The important point is not that a phone replaces a large monitor for deep code reading. It does not. The point is that many reviews are blocked on one or two decisions, and those decisions no longer need to wait until I am back at my desk.

6. Treat permissions as part of the workflow

Remote work is only useful if control stays explicit.

Codex Remote surfaces approval requests for commands, file changes, network access, and connected tools. Depending on the request and host configuration, an approval may apply once, for the current chat, or more broadly.

The power-user move is not to approve everything. It is to choose the narrowest permission that keeps the work moving.

For a well-understood command in a trusted thread, a chat-scoped approval can remove repetitive interruptions. For an unfamiliar command, a sensitive repository, or a request whose effect is unclear, approve once—or deny it and ask Codex to explain or use a safer approach.

You can also choose the thread's broader approval behavior when starting work. Think of this as part of task setup, alongside the host, workspace, branch, and model.

7. Manage context before it becomes a problem

Agent threads are stateful, and long threads eventually accumulate enough context to become slower or less focused.

Codex Remote has a small set of tools for managing that lifecycle:

- `/status` shows session details, workspace, context usage, and available rate-limit information.
- The optional context indicator keeps remaining context visible in the composer.
- `/compact` compresses an overgrown thread while preserving the useful working state.

- `/fork` creates a new thread from the current one when you want shared history but a different direction.

The practical sequence is: Check status, compact when the objective is still the same, and fork when the objective has diverged.

Do not use a side chat and a fork interchangeably. A side chat is a lightweight question around the current work. A fork is a new primary line of work that inherits the thread's history.

8. Keep a clean Thread Desk

My own Codex workflow increasingly looks like a small operations desk.

I pin the few threads that are actively moving, rename them around outcomes, and archive them aggressively once the work is done. Archived-thread browsing makes this safe: Archive is organization, not deletion.

Notifications are part of that system. A completion notification can open the relevant Codex task directly, so the handoff from “agent finished” to “human reviews” is one tap.

Spotlight and Shortcuts can open Codex Remote directly. On iPad, keyboard shortcuts make the app surprisingly efficient: Create a new thread, move between threads, open changed files, pin, rename, and archive without reaching for every control.

This is the “chief of staff” use case for Codex Remote. The app is not only where I issue prompts. It is where I keep track of which pieces of engineering work are active, blocked, waiting for review, or finished.

9. The hidden command palette

Typing `/` reveals the fastest route to many of the app's advanced behaviors. Availability can depend on the connected host, app version, and account configuration.

Command	What it is for
<code>/plan</code>	Toggle Plan mode before implementation.
<code>/goal <objective></code>	Create or update a durable objective.
<code>/side [question]</code>	Ask a side question without disrupting the main thread.
<code>/review</code>	Review local changes or compare them with a branch.

Command	What it is for
<code>/status</code>	Inspect the session, workspace, context, and rate limits.
<code>/compact</code>	Compress a long thread's context.
<code>/fork</code>	Create a new primary thread from the current history.
<code>/fast</code>	Switch between standard and faster execution when available.
<code>/feedback</code>	Send product feedback tied to the current session.

The command palette is worth learning because it exposes the product's real conceptual model: Plan, pursue, branch, review, inspect, and recover.

10. Five workflows that work especially well on mobile

The release captain

Start a focused thread for a release or pull request. Ask Codex to check the current branch, CI state, open review feedback, and release inclusion. Pin the thread. When new information arrives, steer only when it invalidates the active investigation; otherwise, queue it. Review the final diff or release note from the phone and archive the thread when the release lands.

The interrupt-driven bug fix

Attach a screenshot, log, or captured file. Ask Codex to diagnose before editing. Use a side chat to interrogate one suspicious error without derailing the main investigation. Once the cause is clear, return to the main thread and authorize the narrow fix.

The mobile reviewer

Run a review against the intended branch, inspect the changed-file summary, open the files that matter, and attach inline comments. Ask Codex to address only those comments, then review the follow-up diff.

The long-running objective

Create a goal with a concrete completion condition: Tests green, review feedback resolved, or a reproducible performance threshold met. Check progress from notifications and status rather than repeatedly asking "Are you done?" Use queued prompts for additional work and reserve steering for corrections.

The multi-machine operator

Keep hosts named clearly and organize work by machine and workspace. Use the phone to start a task on the machine that has the right checkout, credentials, simulator, or operating system. This is especially useful when one task requires a Mac and another needs a Windows host.

Small features with outsized impact

Some of my favorite additions are not headline features:

- Edit the latest sent prompt instead of adding a correction turn.
- Save or copy rendered images from a task.
- See queued prompts while Codex is still running.
- Open completed tasks directly from notifications.
- Browse archived threads instead of keeping the active list crowded.
- Wrap long diff lines when reading on a narrow screen.
- Use Face ID or the device passcode to protect Codex separately.
- See skills and plugins inline in the composer before sending.
- Capture a photo directly into a prompt when the real-world object is the context.
- Start a side chat from selected transcript text rather than re-explaining the question.

None of these changes the fundamental agent model. Together, they remove the friction that makes a remote workflow feel fragile.

The larger lesson

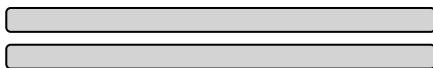
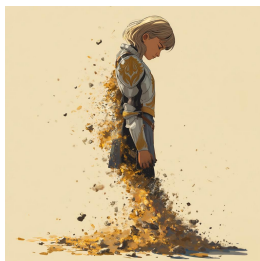
The best mobile software does not shrink a desktop interface. It identifies the decisions that matter when you are away from the desk and makes those decisions fast, legible, and safe.

That is how I think about Codex Remote now. It is where I can choose the right environment, set the objective, redirect a run, answer an approval, inspect the result, and keep the whole queue of engineering work coherent.

The computer still does the work. The phone keeps me in control.

The lies I used to tell myself

CATE HALL · 23 JAN 2026 · [SOURCE](#)



1. What doesn't kill you makes you stronger.

When I was 31, my husband of four years, who I loved more than my own life, left me completely out of the blue. We'd had an incredible, epic romance — drawn together like magnets, we married on our third date and spent the years that followed burrowing ever closer together. Maybe that was the problem — I can't say for sure, because I never got a satisfying explanation out of him. One day I was the protagonist of a Princess Bride-worthy love story; 48 hours later, he moved out.

From the time we met, I had never contemplated the possibility of living without him, and I didn't want to. I wanted to die for a long time — at least a couple of years. But as I slowly learned to sequester away thoughts of him and the emotions they brought up, I became convinced of a silver lining: The experience would make me impenetrable. If I survived it, I would know I could survive anything, and nothing would be able to hurt me again.

It took the better part of a decade and another deeply identity-shifting relationship, with the man who became my second husband, for me to see that I had it all wrong: Impenetrability means avoiding the parts of life that are most life-like. There's a reason the visual metaphor for love is an arrow.

The near-fatal catastrophes of our lives don't always make us stronger. Surviving one hard thing does provide evidence that you can survive other hard things, which is easy to *mistake* for getting stronger. But in reality they often just make us brittle, make us dissociate and flee from the situations that remind us we can be broken.

2. When you know, you know.

Mario Gabriele of the Generalist had a great [“50 Things” style post](#) a few months ago that I found myself nodding along to almost the whole way through. The glaring exception was Number 33: “Love is easy. The difference between bad relationships and meeting your spouse is not a matter of degree, but category. Compatibility is unignorable and effortless.”

I believed this completely, once. I've since come to believe that what's unignorable and effortless is chemistry. Chemistry can be powerful enough to turn your life sideways, but it's not the same thing as compatibility. Compatibility is litigated on the timescale of years and decades; it's not a momentary feeling but a description of what happens during an extended course of change. Do you grow toward one another, or do you grow apart? Does the relationship help you move closer to the person you aspire to be?

I “just knew” with my first husband. I wasn't sure with my second. Four years in, the signs have flipped.

3. If it were a good idea, someone would be doing it already.

There's a belief, especially common among wonky types, that you don't find \$20 bills on the sidewalk — if an opportunity were real, someone would have seized it already. This sounds worldly and wise, but it's actually a form of defensive thinking. It assumes the current way is best, that everything worth doing is being done.

In my experience, this is just false. When I started playing poker, I discovered that physical tells were basically a wide-open field — despite the fact that most pros believed the topic was played out. If you think you see an opportunity others have missed, you should have a story for why they're missing it, and you should ask around to stress-test that story. But if no one can give you a satisfying reason, don't assume one exists. Sometimes the answer really is just inertia or fear.

4. If it's worth doing, it's worth doing well.

Almost nothing is worth doing “well.” Many things can and should be done to a minimal standard of quality, because anything more is a waste of effort that can be better allocated. The exceptions aren't things that should be done “well,” but things that should be done to an exceptionally high standard, probably a much higher one than you see modeled by the people around you.

This is not semantics; most people really “do everything the way they do anything” — whether that's in a low-effort or high-effort way. But the point of phoning it in on a lot of stuff is to save your energy to expend on the 1 in 1000 things that really matter ... and then to actually spend it.

A recent example: I decided that I want to narrate my own audiobook for *You Can Just Do Things*. When I told a friend in the industry this and asked whether they knew any good coaches to work with, they said that hiring a coach wasn't normal or necessary, because my publisher would decide based on a sample whether I was good enough at reading to do it, and if so give me a producer to work with day-of. But it “1 in 1000” matters to me whether the audiobook is so good no one would ever think of returning it on account of the narration, so I'm not interested in the normal-shaped solution that constitutes doing it “well,” I'm interested in the one that causes me to come to mind when someone asks this question. In this case, that means hiring multiple coaches and practicing for months.

5. If you like your job, you're doing something wrong.

Back when I was more alienated from my emotions, I thought about work like this: You have a budget of energy to spend, and the goal is to efficiently convert that energy into impact. You identify the activity that generates the highest impact per unit of energy, and then you spam that button for as many waking hours as you can stomach. Is it any wonder I was always burning out?

What I failed to understand is that energy is not fixed. It's dramatically affected by what you choose to do — some activities increase your energy over time, others deplete it. This feels so obvious to me now that I feel kind of stupid including it here, but I know many people (they are endemic to the Bay Area) who still labor under the false belief. Whether you enjoy what you're doing affects your ability to do it year in and year out, and dismissing this as “selfish” doesn't make it untrue. As my husband puts it, the best use of effortful motivation is to engineer your life to require less of it.

6. “All people are insane. They will do anything at any time, and God help anybody who looks for reasons.”

This line, from Kurt Vonnegut, used to neatly encapsulate the way I understood other people — which is to say, not at all. Trying to figure out why people did what they did, or imagine what they’d do next, seemed like a fool’s errand. I was judgmental about it, too: I assumed this was a problem, not with me, but with everyone else.

I didn’t fundamentally move beyond this belief until recent years, when I came into contact with the Enneagram. I imagine there are other personality typing systems that can do something similar, but the Enneagram was magical for me because it clued me into the fact that people can have very different motivational systems from my own that are still internally coherent and produce good things in the world.

People’s behavior was previously incomprehensible to me because I was imputing my own motivational system to them, trying to figure out what would cause me to act the way they did — essentially, concluding that *their* actions made no sense in light of *my* goals. But people have wildly diverse emotional hardware, which determines what’s rational for them. And my particular personality — independent, moralistic, systematic, challenge-seeking, competitive — is unusual, so I was especially poorly placed to measure others by the yardstick of myself.

This shift in perspective was dramatically good for me and for my relationships with other people. It let me see the ecosystem of psychologies as a kind of miracle — wow, it really does take all kinds — rather than a prompt for cosmic horror. And it gave me confidence that, if I invested in understanding people more deeply, they would eventually cease to be total mysteries, prone to bizarre and unreasonable behavior. As far as I can tell, this is the better part of emotional intelligence.

7. Money can’t buy happiness.

The good version of this advice is: You’ll still have to work at being happy, even if you’re rich. Money in your bank account won’t do it for you, and wealth comes with its own pathologies, like endless status-chasing. But the common gloss — that money stops mattering past some modest threshold — is basically false.

You may have heard there’s research showing money doesn’t buy happiness. That research was explosively popular precisely because it was counterintuitive — it betrayed the commonsense intuition that more money means more freedom, more options, more ability to help people you care about. Turns out it was also riddled with methodological problems. More recent work by Matthew Killingsworth (nominative determinism FTW), using large-scale studies that pinged participants about their happiness at random moments, found steady returns to well-being with

rising income, no plateau in sight. The myth persists because it serves a psychological function: It helps people without money feel better about their situation, and helps the wealthy downplay their advantages. But it's not true.

8. Intuition is fake and rationality solves everything.

I used to be horribly judgmental of people who made decisions based on intuition, as in, “I just do what feels right.” And then I noticed that whenever I overrode my intuitions, I made *terrible* decisions. I hired the wrong people, started projects with the wrong people, dated the wrong people, ate food that made me feel bad, did forms of exercise I found unfun and injurious. I don't have a satisfying theory for why this is, but I know what happens: When I shift from emotional intuition to a logical story about a decision, it's much easier for my reasoning to get hijacked by plausible-sounding directives that turn out to be nonsense.

It took me a long time to learn this, and that might have something to do with my training in law and poker. Overriding intuition in favor of explicit reasoning makes sense in contexts that reward systematic rationality, where you will get separated from your money if you count on gut feelings. But most of life isn't a closed system with enumerated rules and clear outcomes. If you try to explicitly name all the factors that make someone a good friend or co-founder, you might come up with some good indicators, but your crude map will also mislead you about the territory.

This is why “wisdom is knowledge that can't be transmitted.” Wise people have navigational skill, not a long list of rules.

Sign up to be notified when my book, *You Can Just Do Things*, is available for purchase.